



The Social Cost of Impartiality: Moral perceptions of helping are influenced by relationship obligations

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Introduction

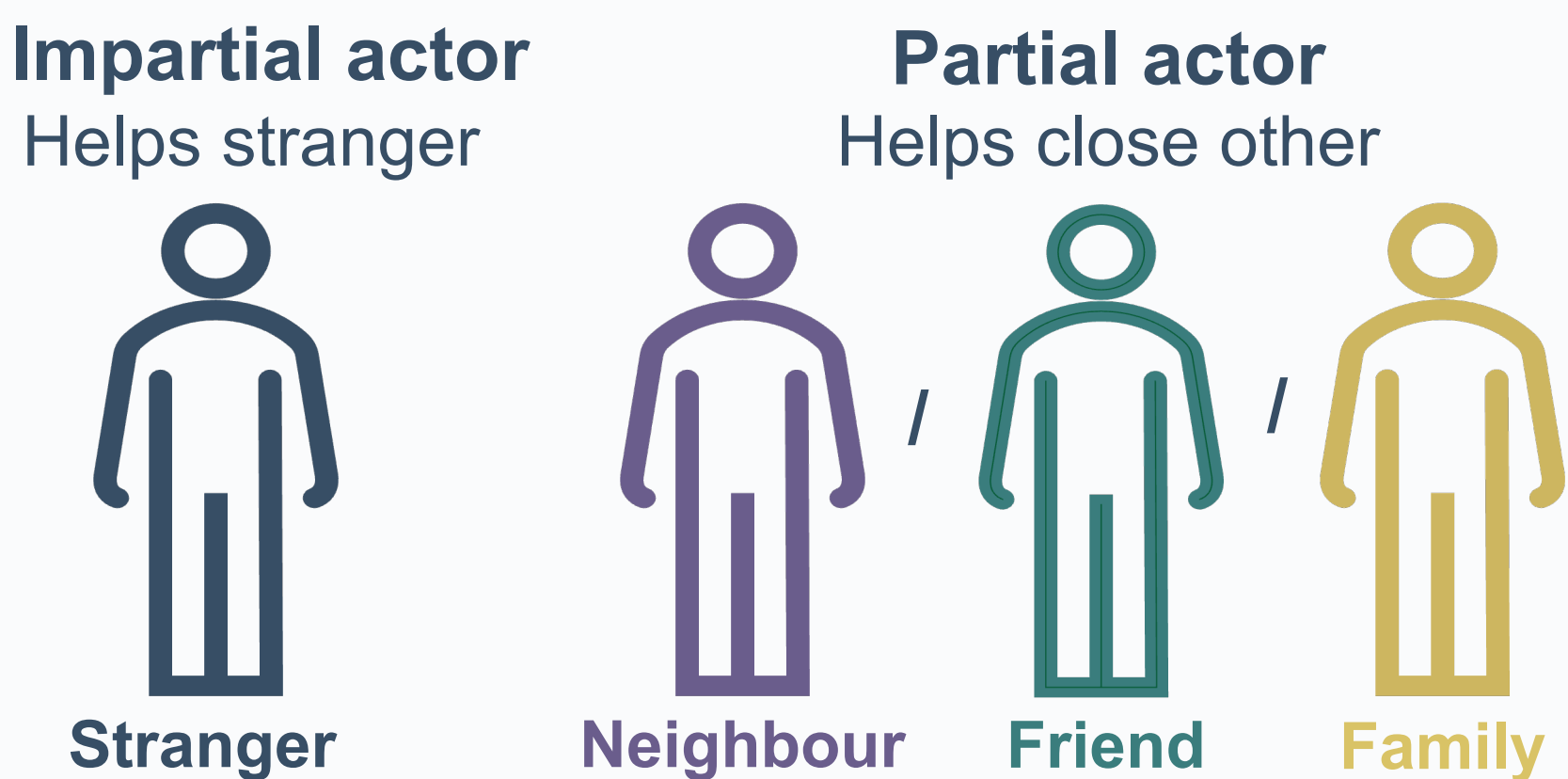
- **The Impartiality ideal**^{1, 2, 3} - many ethical traditions praise treating everyone equally
- **Yet, it is unclear whether people view impartiality as morally good in everyday, relational contexts**^{4, 5}
- **Relationship Regulation**⁶ - different types of relationships entail varying degrees of **moral obligation**
- A certain degree of **partiality** might be **morally expected**⁷ in social relationships
- Impartial actions in close relationships may be seen as **less predictable**^{8, 9} and **less moral**^{7, 10}

Study 1

Do people judge those who help strangers over close others as less moral?

Does relationship closeness (family > friend > neighbour) moderate this effect?

- N = 1017 (51% Female; $M_{\text{age}} = 38.67$, $SD_{\text{age}} = 13.41$)
- 2 (partiality) x 3 (relationship)
- 3 vignettes where both a stranger and a close other need help



- Participants judge actors on several moral dimensions

Study 2

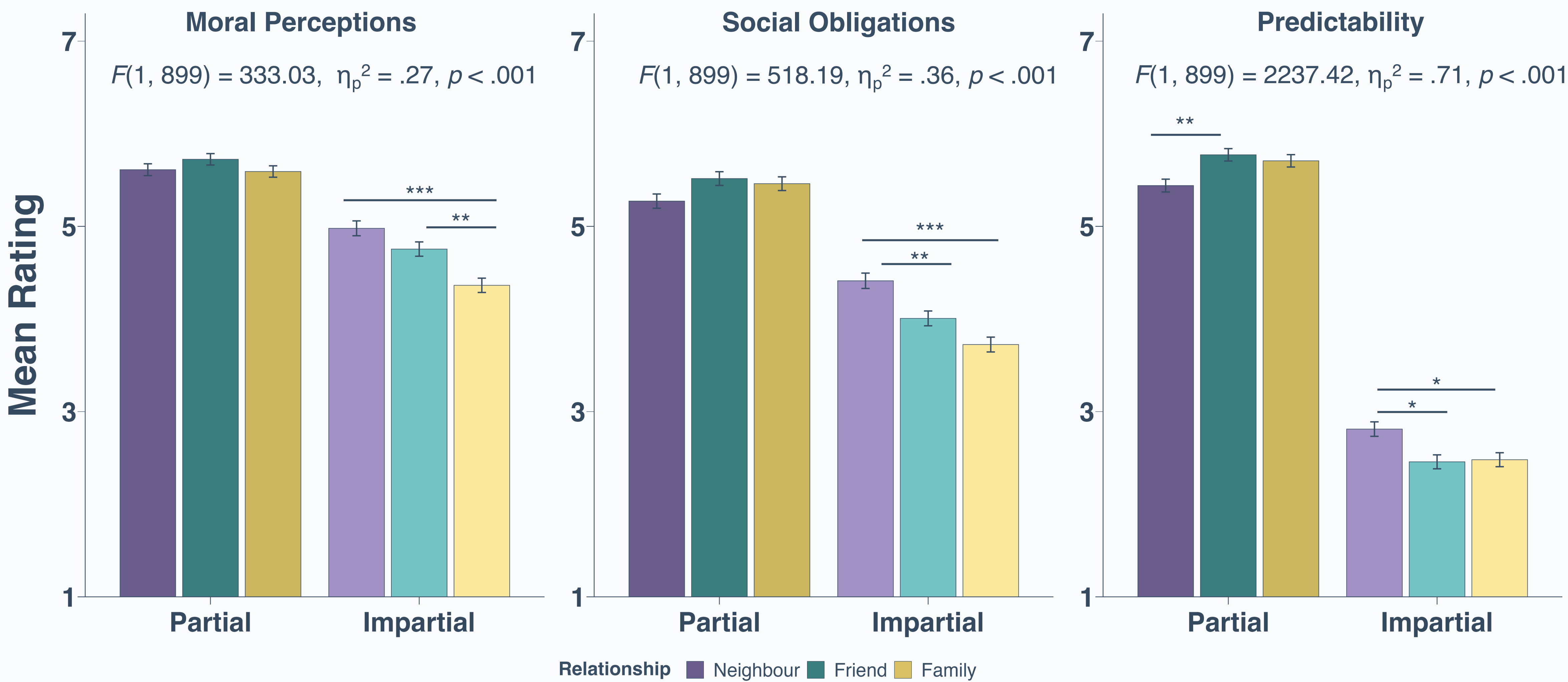
Do participants favor helping close others over strangers?

Does action anonymity change these preferences?

- N = 528 participants (52% Female; $M_{\text{age}} = 38.28$, $SD_{\text{age}} = 13.03$)
- 2 hypothetical donation tasks:
 - Stranger and close other in equal need
 - Stranger in more need than close other
- 3 (relationship) x 2 (donation anonymity)

Results

Study 1 – Impartial actors are perceived as **less moral**, judged as **violating obligations more harshly**, and are seen as **less predictable**. These effects are **amplified for closer relationships**.



Impartiality towards family is seen as less moral than impartiality towards friends and neighbours.

Impartiality towards family and friends is seen as violating obligations more than impartiality towards neighbours.

Impartiality towards neighbours is seen as more predictable than impartiality towards family and friends.

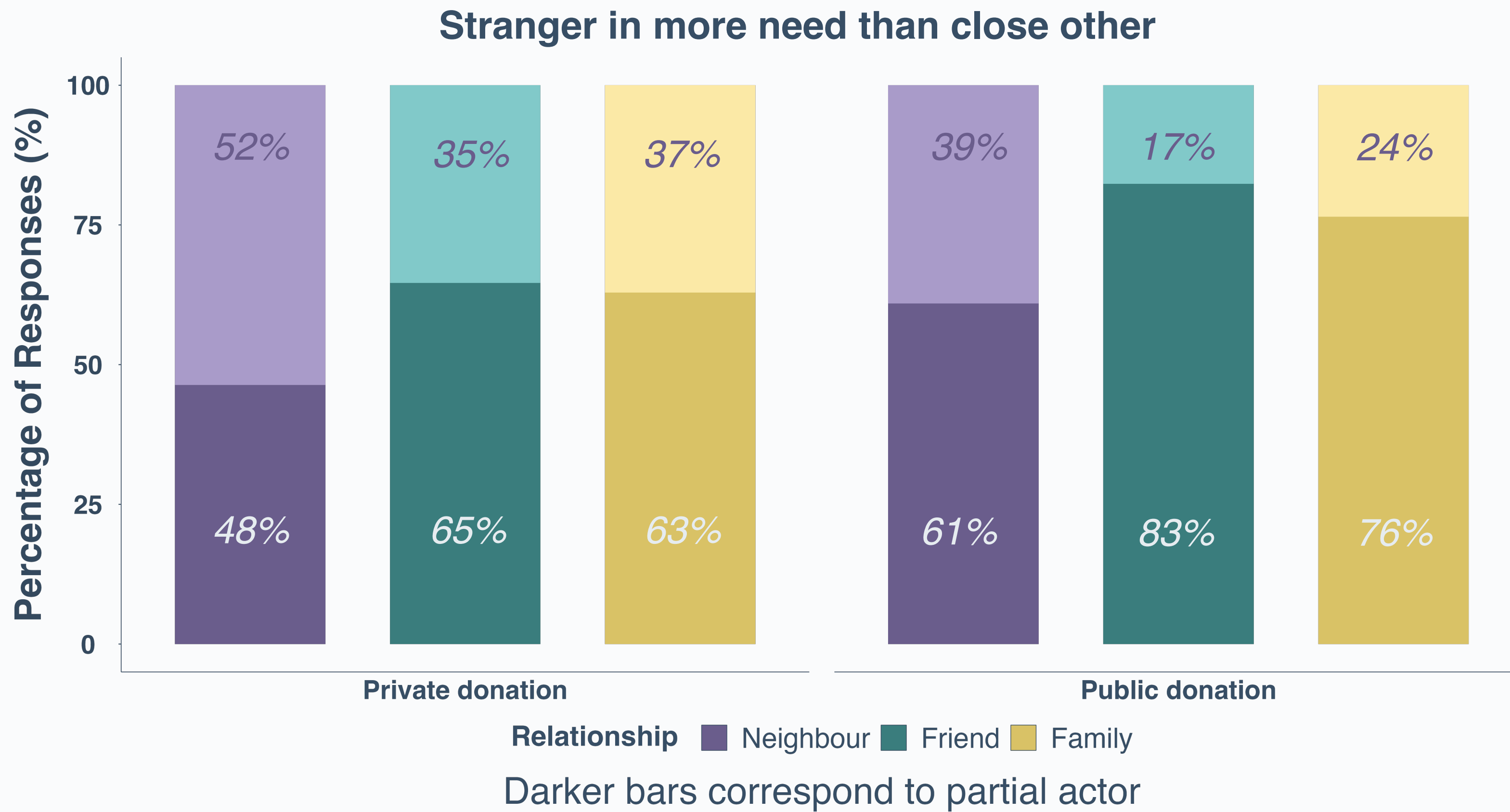
Study 2 – People rarely choose to be impartial when a stranger and a close other are in equal need. Even when a stranger is in greater need, **people are more likely to help a close other** *. **Social visibility increases partiality** compared to private donation decisions.

96.2% of participants chose to donate to a close other when stranger and close other in equal need, $X^2(1) = 344.24$, $p < .001$, regardless of relationship closeness or donation anonymity

65.7% of participants chose to donate to a close other when stranger in more need, $X^2(1) = 42.04$, $p < .001$.

***Partiality preference is weaker for neighbours** compared to friends ($p = .002$) and family ($p = .020$).

Public donation decisions showed **more partiality** than private ones, $X^2(1) = 10.46$, $p = .001$



Conclusions

- Impartial actors are seen in a **more negative light** than partial actors
- Relationship closeness **amplifies moral scrutiny** of impartial actors, suggesting that **partiality is morally expected** in closer relationships
- A **partiality preference** is observed in first-person donation decisions; but people are more willing to **donate to a stranger in greater need in private**
- **Social visibility** increases partiality towards close others, suggesting that people correctly perceive the **social cost of impartiality** in close relationships

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